

Popular music

Pop has its roots in rock 'n' roll and rhythm 'n' blues. Rock music evolved from jazz, blues, and gospel music. Its insistent beat and emotional lyrics helped transform popular music.

SEE ALSO

◀ 146–147 Bass

◀ 166–167 Ostinati, loops, and riffs

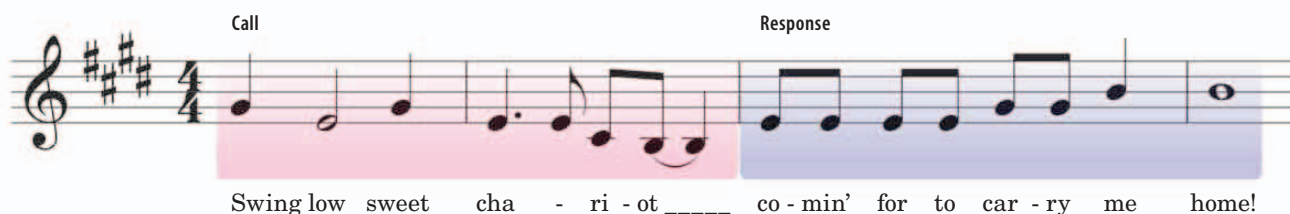
◀ 190–191 Rock bands

Gospel and soul music

Gospel originates from African-American religious songs called spirituals. Sung by groups, gospel music blends harmonies of European hymn tunes, syncopated rhythms and call-and-response patterns from West African music, and the “blue” notes of rhythm 'n' blues melodies. In soul music, the lyrics are generally about human relationships, love, and heartbreak, but the vocal style is similar to gospel music.

▽ Call-and-response

The spiritual song “Swing Low, Sweet Chariot” uses a call-and-response structure between the first and second phrases.



Call Response

Swing low sweet cha - ri - ot co - min' for to car - ry me home!

Pop song characteristics

The lineup for 1960s' pop songs—such as those by The Beatles—was generally guitars, drums, a lead singer, and backing vocals. Most songs had four beats in a measure, simple melodies, and a repeated harmonic sequence, based mainly on chords I, IV, and V.



△ Riff from “Smoke on the Water”

A riff is a short, repeated melodic device that forms the background to a solo or vocal line. “Smoke on the Water” by Deep Purple has a simple, but legendary riff with four pitches.



△ Drum fill

A drum flourish between solos is called a fill. Each different pitch or note head refers to a different drum or cymbal in the drum kit.

This symbol indicates that the staff is for unpitched percussion.

Each of the first three measures takes the lick's melody slightly higher.



△ Typical guitar lick

A lick is a stylish solo phrase, often for a guitar, that follows a vocal phrase. This chromatic four-measure riff reaches its climax in the third measure.